

7 Questions Every CEO Should Ask Before Scaling AI

A practical executive brief for leaders who want AI to create measurable business value without creating unmanaged operational, financial, or governance risk.

VALUE

PROCESS

AI

GOVERNANCE

PROOF

SCALE

YOUR TEAM KNOWS YOUR BUSINESS. WE BRING THE AI.

Evidence over enthusiasm.

Prepared by DEXA Advisors

Enterprise AI Transformation | AI Governance & Risk | AI for Finance & Treasury

AI strategy should begin with business value, not technology.

AI is moving from experimentation into operating processes, customer interactions, financial workflows, decision support, and knowledge work. The strategic question is no longer whether an organization will use AI. The question is whether it can convert AI into durable business value while maintaining accountability and control.

Before approving another pilot, platform, agent, or enterprise license, a CEO should be able to get clear answers to the seven questions below. Weak answers usually signal that the organization is buying capability before it has defined the business problem, operating model, or governance needed to scale.

01 What measurable business outcome are we trying to change?

Start with the economics. The target should be a business outcome such as revenue growth, lower operating cost, shorter cycle time, increased capacity, improved forecast quality, better customer response, or reduced risk. “Use AI” is not an outcome.

EXECUTIVE TEST

Can the initiative be expressed as a baseline, a target, an accountable owner, and a time horizon?

02 Do we understand the real process before we automate it?

AI applied to a poorly understood process can accelerate inconsistency. Map how work actually moves across people, systems, approvals, exceptions, data, and handoffs. The operating truth is often different from the procedure manual or organization chart.

EXECUTIVE TEST

Can the team show the current workflow, its bottlenecks, exceptions, control points, and sources of delay?

03 Is AI actually the right intervention?

Some problems need better data, process redesign, integration, conventional automation, clearer accountability, or better management before they need AI. Use AI where probabilistic reasoning, language, pattern recognition, prediction, or intelligent assistance creates a meaningful advantage.

EXECUTIVE TEST

If AI were removed from the proposal, would the underlying business problem still be clearly defined?

04 What decisions or actions must remain under human control?

Define boundaries before deployment. High-consequence decisions, payments, authorizations, access changes, regulatory judgments, and irreversible actions may require explicit human review or deterministic controls. Governance is stronger when it is enforced in the operating design, not merely written in a policy.

EXECUTIVE TEST

Can leadership state what AI may recommend, what it may execute, and what it must never control autonomously?

05 Can we trust the data and systems the AI will depend on?

AI does not repair weak data foundations by itself. Determine what data is required, who owns it, whether it is accurate and permitted for the intended use, and how sensitive information will be protected. Examine integration, identity, access, logging, retention, and vendor dependencies.

EXECUTIVE TEST

Do we know the source, owner, sensitivity, quality, access rights, and audit trail for the information feeding the system?

06 How will we prove value and safety before scaling?

A pilot should test a business hypothesis, not merely demonstrate impressive technology. Define success metrics, failure modes, control tests, user acceptance criteria, and financial thresholds in advance. Start with the smallest useful system that can generate credible evidence.

EXECUTIVE TEST

What evidence would cause us to scale, redesign, pause, or stop the initiative?

07 Who owns the AI after the consultants and project team leave?

Scaled AI needs durable ownership. Someone must be accountable for business performance, application behavior, controls, data, incidents, vendor changes, monitoring, user training, and policy updates. If ownership disappears when the project ends, governance will eventually disappear with it.

EXECUTIVE TEST

Can we name the business owner, technology owner, risk owner, and escalation path for the production system?

THE DEXA PRINCIPLE

The goal is not more AI. The goal is better business.

Value first. Understand the process. Choose the right intervention. Establish boundaries. Prove the economics and controls. Then scale what works.

A SIMPLE DECISION FILTER

Before scaling, leadership should be able to say:

VALUE	We know what economic or operational outcome will improve.
PROCESS	We understand how the work actually happens.
FIT	We know why AI is preferable to simpler interventions.
BOUNDARIES	We know what AI may and may not do.
FOUNDATION	We trust the required data, access, and system controls.
EVIDENCE	We know what must be proven before expansion.
OWNERSHIP	Named executives remain accountable after deployment.

DEXA ADVISORS

Start with one process.

Dexa Advisors helps established organizations identify where AI can create measurable value, understand the operating process behind the opportunity, establish appropriate boundaries and governance, and build practical roadmaps from opportunity to implementation to responsible scale.

BRING ONE BUSINESS BOTTLENECK.

One operational process, finance or treasury workflow, or AI initiative is enough to start a serious conversation.

ALEX KALAMBATA

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